

Study Report: Dynamics 365 CRM Consultant - Career Path & Core Skills

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Family:	Dynamics 365 CRM Consultant
Level:	Beginner to Advanced
Tracks:	Beginner, Intermediate, Advanced
Chapters:	18
Source:	Official docs, free libraries, and industry-standard references (see sources and books)

Official sources and free libraries

- <https://learn.microsoft.com/training/dynamics365/>
- <https://learn.microsoft.com/power-apps/maker/data-platform/>
- <https://learn.microsoft.com/dynamics365/customerengagement/>
- <https://learn.microsoft.com/power-automate/>
- <https://learn.microsoft.com/power-platform/alm/>
- <https://learn.microsoft.com/dynamics365/release-plan/>

Summary

Microsoft Dynamics 365 career path covering Sales and Customer Service apps, Dataverse tables and relationships, model-driven app design, business process flows, Power Automate cloud flows, security roles, ALM with solutions, and official Microsoft Learn modules for MB-910 and PL-200 alignment.

Skill stack by level

Recommended books

1. Microsoft Dynamics 365 Documentation - Microsoft Learn

Level: Beginner | Official guides for Sales, Customer Service, and Dataverse.

2. Mastering Microsoft Dynamics 365 Development - Packt

Level: Advanced | Plugins, custom APIs, and Dataverse extension patterns.

3. Dynamics 365 For Dummies - Renato Fajdiga

Level: Beginner | CRM concepts, leads, opportunities, and customer service cases.

4. Microsoft Power Platform Enterprise Architecture - Microsoft Press

Level: Advanced | ALM, environments, and solution layering for Dynamics + Power Platform.

5. MB-910 Study Guide - Microsoft Learn

Level: Beginner | Free learning path for Dynamics 365 Fundamentals CRM exam.

End-to-end projects

Project 1: Contact Management App

Beginner | 2 weeks - Model-driven app for contacts and accounts with custom views, forms, and business rules on Dataverse.

- Tables: Schema screenshot
- Forms: Form screenshots
- Views: View list screenshot
- App: Published app URL

Project 2: Customer Service Case Management

Intermediate | 3-4 weeks - Case entity with queues, SLAs, routing rules, knowledge articles, and Power Automate notifications.

- Cases: Case form screenshot
- SLA: SLA config doc
- Routing: Routing test cases
- Automate: Flow demo video

Project 3: Sales Pipeline with Power Platform ALM

Advanced | 4-5 weeks - Full sales solution in managed solution: dev ? test ? prod with plugins, flows, and security roles.

- Solution: Solution export
- Plugin: Plugin + tests
- ALM: ALM pipeline doc
- Security: Security test matrix

Chapters

Track: Beginner

Chapter 1: Dynamics 365 and Power Platform Overview [Beginner]

Chapter focus: Dynamics 365 and Power Platform Overview** *(Level: Beginner)

Dynamics 365 Customer Engagement apps run on Dataverse-a cloud database with APIs, security, and metadata. Power Apps, Power Automate, and Power BI share the platform. Model-driven apps auto-generate UI from Dataverse schema; canvas apps offer pixel control.

Code Reference:

```
# pac auth create --url https://org.crm.dynamics.com
# pac org list
```

What it shows: PAC CLI authenticates to environments for ALM automation.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Dynamics 365 is Microsoft's cloud CRM and ERP suite on Dataverse.

When to use it

Sales, service, marketing, and field service implementations.

Where to use it

Microsoft-centric enterprises and partners.

Real use example

CodeQuest partner provisions Sales trial environment via Microsoft 365 tenant.

Chapter 2: Dataverse Tables and Columns [Beginner]

Chapter focus: Dataverse Tables and Columns** *(Level: Beginner)

Tables (entities) store rows (records). Columns have types: text, choice, lookup, currency, datetime. Lookups create relationships; 1:N and N:N need intersect tables. Use solutions to package customizations for promotion.

Code Reference:

```
# Display name: Course Enrollment | Schema name: cq_enrollment  
# Lookup to Contact and Course tables
```

What it shows: Naming comments document custom table design for team alignment.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Dataverse is the metadata-driven data layer for Power Platform.

When to use it

Every CRM customization and integration project.

Where to use it

Sales pipelines, case management, and custom LOB apps.

Real use example

Custom cq_enrollment table links students (contacts) to CodeQuest courses.

Chapter 3: Model-Driven App Design [Beginner]

Chapter focus: Model-Driven App Design** *(Level: Beginner)

Model-driven apps compose sitemap, forms, views, charts, and business process flows. Main form tabs organize fields; quick create forms speed inline entry. Unified interface is mandatory for new apps. Test with multiple security roles.

Code Reference:

```
# App module: Sales Hub -> Accounts, Contacts, Opportunities, custom Enrollments
```

What it shows: Sitemap comments map navigation structure for makers.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Model-driven apps deliver consistent CRM UX from metadata.

When to use it

Internal sales and service teams needing standardized processes.

Where to use it

Dynamics 365 Sales and Customer Service out-of-box apps.

Real use example

Enrollment table added to Sales Hub sitemap under Accounts area.

Chapter 4: Forms, Views, and Dashboards [Beginner]

Chapter focus: Forms, Views, and Dashboards** *(Level: Beginner)

Forms use sections, tabs, and controls (subgrids, timelines). Views define filtered columns for grids; system views ship with apps. Dashboards combine charts and lists for role-based landing experiences.

Code Reference:

```
# View: Active District Opportunities | Filter: Status = Open | Sort: Est. Close Date
```

What it shows: View definitions document saved queries for makers.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Forms and views shape daily user productivity in CRM.

When to use it

Every user-facing CRM customization.

Where to use it

Sales managers, service agents, and executives.

Real use example

Service dashboard shows open P1 cases by account for morning standup.

Chapter 5: Security Roles and Teams [Beginner]

Chapter focus: Security Roles and Teams** *(Level: Beginner)

Security roles grant table privileges: Create, Read, Write, Delete, Append, Assign, Share. Teams

own records for collaborative access. Field security profiles mask sensitive columns. Hierarchy security restricts manager visibility down org chart.

Code Reference:

```
# Role: CodeQuest Sales Rep -> Account: Read/Write Organization, Contact: Read/Write User
```

What it shows: Privilege comments clarify role design worksheets.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Dataverse security enforces least privilege at row and column level.

When to use it

New implementations and access reviews.

Where to use it

Multi-department Dynamics deployments.

Real use example

Agent role cannot delete cases; only managers can reassign queues.

Chapter 6: Dynamics 365 Sales Essentials [Beginner]

Chapter focus: Dynamics 365 Sales Essentials *(Level: Beginner)**

Sales tracks leads (optional), accounts, contacts, opportunities with stages and forecasts. Activities log calls and emails. Integration with Outlook and Teams embeds CRM in daily flow. Revenue forecasting uses opportunity categories and pipeline views.

Code Reference:

```
# Opportunity stages: Qualify -> Develop -> Propose -> Close  
# Close as Won triggers enrollment provisioning flow
```

What it shows: Stage comments tie BPF design to revenue process.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Dynamics 365 Sales manages B2B relationship and pipeline lifecycle.

When to use it

B2B sales teams and partner co-selling.

Where to use it

Technology, education, and professional services firms.

Real use example

District opportunity Won triggers Power Automate to provision sandbox org.

Track: Intermediate

Chapter 7: Business Process Flows [Intermediate]

Chapter focus: Business Process Flows** *(Level: Intermediate)

BPFs guide users stage-by-stage with required steps and field visibility. Use branching BPF for different paths. BPFs stored as Dataverse components-version with solutions. Combine with Power Automate for stage-entry automation.

Code Reference:

```
# BPF: Case Resolution | Stages: Identify -> Research -> Resolve -> Review
```

What it shows: Stage pipeline mirrors service desk standard operating procedure.

Topic guide

What it actually is

BPFs enforce process discipline without custom code.

When to use it

Qualification, case resolution, and onboarding processes.

Where to use it

Regulated workflows needing audit trails.

Real use example

Case stuck in Research stage highlights bottleneck in weekly ops review.

Chapter 8: Power Automate Cloud Flows for CRM [Intermediate]

Chapter focus: Power Automate Cloud Flows for CRM** *(Level: Intermediate)

Cloud flows trigger on Dataverse row create/update, schedules, or HTTP requests. Use connection references in solutions for ALM. Implement error scopes, retries, and environment variable secrets-not hardcoded credentials.

Code Reference:

```
# Trigger: When a row is added or modified (Case)
# Condition: Priority = Critical -> Post adaptive card to Teams
```

What it shows: Flow outline documents trigger-condition-action pattern.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Power Automate connects CRM events to Microsoft 365 and external APIs.

When to use it

Notifications, approvals, sync jobs, and case routing.

Where to use it

Every Dynamics implementation beyond out-of-box.

Real use example

Critical case flow pages on-call engineer and creates Planner task automatically.

Chapter 9: Customer Service and SLAs [Intermediate]**Chapter focus: Customer Service and SLAs** *(Level: Intermediate)**

Customer Service manages cases, queues, entitlements, and SLAs with KPI timers (first response, resolve by). Unified Routing assigns to agents by skills. IoT and Field Service extend for device-triggered cases.

Code Reference:

```
# SLA KPI: First Response in 1 hour | Warning at 45 min | Failure escalates
```

What it shows: SLA timer configuration prevents silent breaches.

Topic guide**What it actually is**

Customer Service app handles post-sale support operations.

When to use it

Help desks, product support, and managed services.

Where to use it

SaaS vendors supporting education customers.

Real use example

SLA failure on district outage case auto-escalates to major incident queue.

Chapter 10: Plugins and Custom APIs (Overview) [Intermediate]**Chapter focus: Plugins and Custom APIs (Overview)** *(Level: Intermediate)**

Plugins are .NET assemblies registered on Dataverse messages (Create, Update). Synchronous plugins run in transaction; async in queue. Prefer low-code before code-use plugins for complex validation, integration, or pre/post images.

Code Reference:

```
// Plugin: PreOperation on Opportunity Update validates discount threshold
```

What it shows: Plugin stage comment clarifies when logic executes in pipeline.

Topic guide**What it actually is**

Server-side extensions implement logic Flow cannot handle.

When to use it

Complex validations, integrations, and performance-critical rules.

Where to use it

Enterprise Dynamics teams with developers.

Real use example

Plugin blocks unauthorized discount >30% before save completes.

Chapter 11: Integrations and Dual-Write [Intermediate]

Chapter focus: Integrations and Dual-Write *(Level: Intermediate)**

Dataverse Web API and SDK enable CRUD from external systems. Dual-write syncs Finance and Operations tables with CE in real time. Azure Service Bus and Logic Apps provide enterprise messaging patterns.

Code Reference:

```
Invoke-RestMethod -Uri '$org/api/data/v9.2/accounts' -Headers $headers -Method Get
```

What it shows: PowerShell calls Dataverse Web API for admin automation scripts.

Topic guide**What it actually is**

Integrations connect CRM to ERP, marketing, and analytics platforms.

When to use it

Order-to-cash, customer 360, and billing alignment.

Where to use it

Manufacturing and retail with D365 Finance + CE.

Real use example

Dual-write keeps account credit limit from Finance visible to sales reps.

Chapter 12: Reports and Power BI for CRM [Intermediate]

Chapter focus: Reports and Power BI for CRM *(Level: Intermediate)**

FetchXML queries feed SSRS and Power BI datasets. Use Dataverse connector in Power BI with row-level security mirroring CRM roles. Embedded analytics surface KPIs inside model-driven apps.

Code Reference:

```
# FetchXML aggregate opportunity revenue by owner  
# Power BI dataset refresh via data gateway
```

What it shows: FetchXML and Power BI comments link reporting layers.

Topic guide

What it actually is

CRM analytics turn pipeline and case data into executive insight.

When to use it

QBRs, service reviews, and sales commission reporting.

Where to use it

Organizations standardizing on Microsoft data stack.

Real use example

Embedded pipeline chart in Sales app shows rep attainment vs quota.

Chapter 13: Solutions and Environment Strategy [Intermediate]

Chapter focus: Solutions and Environment Strategy** *(Level: Intermediate)

Default solution is scratchpad; use publisher-named solutions for ALM. Managed solutions lock metadata in target environments. Environment groups and pipelines automate promotion.

Code Reference:

```
pac solution export --path ./out --managed true --name CodeQuestCore
```

What it shows: PAC exports managed solution artifact for pipeline deploy.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Solution strategy prevents unmanaged customization sprawl.

When to use it

Multi-environment Dynamics programs.

Where to use it

Partners and IT departments with formal release cadence.

Real use example

Unmanaged hotfixes merged back into dev solution before next managed release.

Track: Advanced

Chapter 14: Performance Tuning and Throttling [Advanced]

Chapter focus: Performance Tuning and Throttling** *(Level: Advanced)

Avoid plugin recursion and nested sync workflows. Batch plugins should use ExecuteMultiple. Monitor API service protection limits. Index alternate keys for integration idempotency. Archive old cases to maintain performance.

Code Reference:

```
# Service protection API limit: 429 Too Many Requests -> exponential backoff
```

What it shows: Throttling guidance informs integration retry policies.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Performance tuning keeps CRM responsive at enterprise scale.

When to use it

High-volume portals and integration-heavy orgs.

Where to use it

Global service teams with millions of cases yearly.

Real use example

Archive job moves closed cases >2 years to long-term storage-grid load improves 40%.

Chapter 15: Power Pages and External Portals [Advanced]

Chapter focus: Power Pages and External Portals** *(Level: Advanced)

Power Pages (formerly portals) expose Dataverse data externally with authentication, entity lists, forms, and Web API. Configure table permissions and web roles carefully-portal security misconfigurations are common breach vectors.

Code Reference:

```
# Web role: District Admin | Table permission: Account Read scope Parent
```

What it shows: Portal permission comments document external access model.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Power Pages deliver secure customer and partner self-service.

When to use it

Case submission, knowledge bases, and partner registration.

Where to use it

Education districts accessing support without full CRM license.

Real use example

District admin submits case via portal-creates CRM case with correct entitlement.

Chapter 16: Event Framework and Async Processing [Advanced]

Chapter focus: Event Framework and Async Processing** *(Level: Advanced)

Use async plugins and Azure Functions triggered by Dataverse events for heavy processing.

Service Bus topics decouple publishers. Custom APIs provide typed operations for LWC/canvas clients needing transactional bundles.

Code Reference:

```
// Custom API: cq_ProvisionTenant bundles 5 internal operations atomically
```

What it shows: Custom API comment shows operation bundling pattern.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Event-driven extensions scale beyond synchronous limits.

When to use it

Provisioning, ERP sync, and ML inference side effects.

Where to use it

Large SaaS operators on Dynamics platform.

Real use example

Tenant provision API rolls back all steps if sandbox creation fails.

Chapter 17: Center of Excellence and Governance [Advanced]

Chapter focus: Center of Excellence and Governance *(Level: Advanced)**

Establish COE with DLP policies, environment routing, maker onboarding, and solution review boards. Monitor tenant analytics for orphan flows and overprivileged connectors.

Code Reference:

```
Get-AdminPowerApp | Where-Object {$_.OwnerName -eq 'Departed User'}
```

What it shows: PowerShell identifies orphaned apps for governance cleanup.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Governance keeps Power Platform tenant secure and manageable.

When to use it

Enterprises with citizen developers and pro developers.

Where to use it

Multi-business-unit Microsoft tenants.

Real use example

COE blocks consumer OneDrive connector in production DLP policy.

Chapter 18: Copilot and AI in Dynamics 365 [Advanced]

Chapter focus: Copilot and AI in Dynamics 365 *(Level: Advanced)**

Copilot in Sales and Service summarizes records, drafts emails, and suggests knowledge articles. Understand data residency, prompt logging, and human review for regulated industries. Extend with plugins to ground responses in Dataverse data.

Code Reference:

```
# Copilot Studio agent grounded on Knowledge articles + Dataverse FAQ table
```

What it shows: Grounding comment stresses verified data sources for AI answers.

Topic guide

What it actually is

Dynamics AI features accelerate reps while requiring governance.

When to use it

High-touch sales and service teams adopting Microsoft Copilot.

Where to use it

Organizations already on M365 Copilot roadmap.

Real use example

Agent drafts case summary from email thread-human verifies before sending to district.